PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Mercedes-Benz G-Class W461

1992–2022 · W461 · G 290 GD · G 300 CDI Professional

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Know which W461 you're looking at**
  Ex-military trucks such as the Bundeswehr Wolf, the civilian EDITION.30 PUR and the G 280/300 CDI Professional are all W461s, but they differ in electrics, equipment and paperwork. Check the VIN and the Mercedes data card rather than the seller's description.
- [ ] **24-volt systems**
  Military W461s run 24 V, and parts follow suit. Expedition Imports sells separate 12 V and 24 V heater blower motors, for example. Make sure accessories, lights and chargers match the system, and that no previous owner has half-converted it.
- [ ] **Rust in the usual G places**
  These are steel bodies on a steel frame, and ex-fleet trucks often lived outdoors. Handsome Motors' G checklist covers the windscreen gasket, door hinges, rear spring perch mounts, the metal under the tail-lights and rear door, and the body seams; Autocar adds the inner wheel arches.
- [ ] **Cardan shaft recall (late diesels)**
  Autocar reports that Mercedes recalled G 280 CDI and G 300 CDI models built between 4 April 2016 and 13 September 2021: the cardan shaft can strike the clamping body, causing power loss and transmission failure. Confirm the recall work has been done.
- [ ] **Lockers and low range**
  Engage low range, then each lock in turn on loose ground. If a lock won't engage, specialists say to flush the hydraulic system first before chasing parts.
- [ ] **Springs and shocks**
  Autocar notes that G-Class coil springs crack, especially in cold weather, and a loud thump over bumps is the clue. Ex-fleet trucks may have had hard lives, so check the dampers and the bushings on the radius arms and Panhard rods.
- [ ] **Set your expectations on pace**
  A naturally aspirated 290 GD makes 95 PS and needs 25–27 seconds to reach 100 km/h. The 1998–2001 turbodiesel, the CDIs and the G 300 CDI are far happier at highway speed.

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- [ ] **Chassis number**
  BaT-sold W461s carry the 461 model code: 1991–92 250 GD Wolfs are WDB461401…, 1993–94 290 GDs WDB46133…. Puch-badged 230 GEs use a VAG prefix (VAG461217…).

- [ ] **Wolf or W460?**
  Expedition Motor Company, which restores them, calls the 250 GD Wolf an ex-military W461, and Wikipedia lists the 1990–91 Wolf under the W461. Check the VIN and data card on the truck in front of you.
- [ ] **24-volt electrics**
  Military W461s run 24-volt systems, and parts suppliers stock 24 V components such as blower motors. The Australian civilian Professional wagon is described as carrying two 12-volt batteries. Check before wiring in accessories.
- [ ] **Running gear**
  Wikipedia describes the W461 as the narrow W460 body with the W463 powertrain. The G 300 CDI Professional has permanent 4WD with a 50:50 split, a two-speed transfer case and three diff locks you can select on the move.
- [ ] **Engine swaps**
  OM606 and other turbodiesel conversions turn up on Bring a Trailer; two OM606-swapped 240 GDs filed there under the W461 sold for $20,500 and $55,000. Check the engine number against the model badge.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/g-class/w461/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks